Comprehensive Guide to Boids Flocking Simulation & Self-Organizing Swarm Intelligence on Mobile

Pocket Lab — Episode 02

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1 Scientific Background & Physical Intuition

In non-equilibrium statistical physics and the theory of complex systems, many natural phenomena exhibit highly structured, coherent, and seemingly intelligent macro-behaviors without any central coordination, external pacing, or presiding hierarchy. This profound transition is termed **Emergence** or **Self-Organization**.

Leaderless Collective Intelligence

The mesmerizing murmurations of starlings sweeping across dusk skies, the synchronized flashings of fireflies, and the evasive bifurcations of fish schools navigating around predators all operate without a central commander. In these architectures:

- No individual agent possesses global knowledge of the collective configuration.
- No centralized radio broadcast, telepathic synchronization, or systemic master plan exists.
- Each individual merely executes simple, deterministic sensory responses to its **immediate local neighbors**.

Global coherence is thus a **bottom-up emergent property** born out of localized inter-agent interactions, rather than a top-down executive command.

The Boids Model (Craig Reynolds, 1986)

In 1986, computer scientist Craig Reynolds developed the **Boids** algorithmic architecture (short for *bird-oid objects*). Reynolds proved that complex collective maneuvering does not require heavy computational artificial intelligence or trajectory optimization. Instead, three elementary kinematic steering rules applied to localized neighbors suffice to produce organic, lifelike flocking. This groundbreaking work became the foundational standard for cinematic flocking simulations, notably utilized by Disney to render the wildebeest stampede in *The Lion King*.

2 Mathematical Formulation & Vector Steering Dynamics

Consider an ensemble of N discrete self-propelled boids confined within a two-dimensional domain $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^2$. The state of each boid $i \in \{1, \dots, N\}$ is characterized by its instantaneous spatial position vector $\mathbf{x}_i(t) \in \mathbb{R}^2$ and translational velocity vector $\mathbf{v}_i(t) \in \mathbb{R}^2$.

Neighborhood Topology

Visual perception is localized and bounded by a metric perception horizon R_{vis}. The neighborhood set N_i of agent i is defined as:

$$N_i = \{j \in \{1, \dots, N\} \mid 0 < \|\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i\| \leq R_{\text{vis}}\} \tag{1}$$

A smaller spatial threshold, the separation radius $R_{\text{sep}} < R_{\text{vis}}$, defines the physical personal space required to avert immediate collisions:

$$N_i^{\text{close}} = \{j \in N_i \mid \|\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i\| \leq R_{\text{sep}}\} \tag{2}$$

Reynolds' Three Canonical Steering Rules

The net acceleration vector governing each individual agent is composed of three localized steering forces:

$$\mathbf{F}_{\text{total}}^{(i)} = w_{\text{sep}}\mathbf{F}_{\text{sep}}^{(i)} + w_{\text{ali}}\mathbf{F}_{\text{ali}}^{(i)} + w_{\text{coh}}\mathbf{F}_{\text{coh}}^{(i)} + \mathbf{F}_{\text{bound}}^{(i)} \tag{3}$$

1. Separation ($\mathbf{F}_{\text{sep}}$) — Collision Avoidance

To prevent overcrowding and spatial intersections, an inverse-distance repulsive steering force acts against near neighbors:

$$\mathbf{F}_{\text{sep}}^{(i)} = -\sum_{j \in N_i^{\text{close}}} \frac{\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i}{\|\mathbf{x}_j - \mathbf{x}_i\| + \epsilon} \tag{4}$$

where $\epsilon > 0$ regularizes the singularity at zero separation.

2. Alignment ($\mathbf{F}_{\text{ali}}$) — Velocity Matching

Each agent steers toward the mean velocity vector of its surrounding flockmates:

$$\mathbf{F}_{\text{ali}}^{(i)} = \left(\frac{1}{|N_i|} \sum_{j \in N_i} \mathbf{v}_j \right) - \mathbf{v}_i \tag{5}$$

3. Cohesion ($\mathbf{F}_{\text{coh}}$) — Center of Mass Attraction

To preserve flock integrity and prevent isolation, each boid is attracted to the local geometric centroid:

$$\mathbf{F}_{\text{coh}}^{(i)} = \left(\frac{1}{|N_i|} \sum_{j \in N_i} \mathbf{x}_j \right) - \mathbf{x}_i \tag{6}$$

Kinematic Clamping and Boundary Confinement

Biological musculature imposes strict kinematic constraints on steering forces and terminal velocities. Acceleration and velocity vectors are bounded by hard saturation operators:

$$\text{clamp}(\mathbf{u}, u_{\max}) = \begin{cases} \mathbf{u}, & \|\mathbf{u}\| \le u_{\max} \\ u_{\max} \frac{\mathbf{u}}{\|\mathbf{u}\|}, & \|\mathbf{u}\| > u_{\max} \end{cases} \tag{7}$$

To keep agents within a standard vertical 9:16 mobile canvas without artificial wrap-around teleportation, a continuous linear repulsive margin force ($\mathbf{F}_{\text{bound}}$) deflects agents smoothly away from the borders.

Macroscopic Metric: Polarization Order Parameter

To quantify the phase transition from initial micro-disorder to macro-flocking, we measure the global normalized polarization parameter $\Phi(t) \in [0\%, 100\%]$:

$$\Phi(t) = \frac{\left\| \sum_{i=1}^{N} \mathbf{v}_i(t) \right\|}{\sum_{i=1}^{N} \|\mathbf{v}_i(t)\|} \times 100\% \tag{8}$$

- When velocity headings are isotropic and randomized, destructive interference yields $\Phi(t) \approx 0\%$ (**Disordered Phase**).
- When all agents travel along an identical trajectory, constructive interference yields $\Phi(t) \approx 100\%$ (**Coherent Swarm Phase**).

3 Environment Setup & Prerequisites

The entire computational workflow leverages high-performance vectorized NumPy operations and renders natively on smartphone architectures.

Native Execution: Termux on Android

Log in to your localized Ubuntu userland environment via PRoot:

```
proot-distro login ubuntu
```

Ensure the core scientific Python and imaging toolchains are installed:

```
apt update && apt install python3 python3-numpy python3-matplotlib
   python3-pil -y
```

> **Cloud Alternative (iOS & Web Browsers):** Users on iOS or those opting for a browser-based runtime can open Google Colab, create a new notebook, paste the code into a cell, and render the output without manual local configuration.

4 Complete Python Implementation (`boids_simulation_20s.py`)

The following script executes a 20-second simulation (500 frames at 25 FPS) structured for a 9:16 aspect ratio. It features real-time color adaptation based on local synchronization and an integrated scientific HUD:

```
import numpy as np
import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
from matplotlib.animation import FuncAnimation, PillowWriter

# ========================================
# 1. SIMULATION SETUP & CONSTANTS (20 SECONDS)
# ========================================
FPS = 25
DURATION_SEC = 20
TOTAL_FRAMES = DURATION_SEC * FPS # Exactly 500 frames

NUM_BOIDS = 130
WIDTH, HEIGHT = 100.0, 177.7 # Exact 9:16 vertical ratio

# Behavioral Radii & Kinematics
VISUAL_RADIUS = 16.0
MIN_DISTANCE = 4.2
MAX_SPEED = 2.6
MAX_FORCE = 0.14

W_SEP = 1.8 # Rule 1: Separation (Avoid collisions)
W_ALI = 1.1 # Rule 2: Alignment (Match neighbors' heading)
W_COH = 0.9 # Rule 3: Cohesion (Stay close to group center)
```

```

# Initialize positions and randomized velocities
np.random.seed(42)
positions = np.random.rand(NUM_BOIDS, 2) * [WIDTH, HEIGHT]
angles = np.random.rand(NUM_BOIDS) * 2 * np.pi
velocities = np.column_stack([np.cos(angles), np.sin(angles)]) * MAX_SPEED

# ========================================
# 2. NUMERICAL KINEMATICS ENGINE
# ========================================
def update_physics(pos, vel):
    diff = pos[np.newaxis, :, :] - pos[:, np.newaxis, :]
    dist = np.linalg.norm(diff, axis=2)

    in_range = (dist > 0) & (dist < VISUAL_RADIUS)
    too_close = (dist > 0) & (dist < MIN_DISTANCE)

    sep_steer = np.zeros_like(vel)
    ali_steer = np.zeros_like(vel)
    coh_steer = np.zeros_like(vel)
    local_order = np.zeros(NUM_BOIDS)

    for i in range(NUM_BOIDS):
        neighbors = in_range[i]
        close_neighbors = too_close[i]

        # 1. Separation
        if np.any(close_neighbors):
            repulsion = -diff[i, close_neighbors] / (dist[i, close_neighbors, np.
                newaxis] + 1e-4)
            sep_steer[i] = np.sum(repulsion, axis=0)

        # 2. Alignment & 3. Cohesion
        if np.any(neighbors):
            avg_vel = np.mean(vel[neighbors], axis=0)
            ali_steer[i] = avg_vel - vel[i]
            coh_steer[i] = np.mean(diff[i, neighbors], axis=0)

            # Local alignment index (0.0 = chaotic, 1.0 = aligned)
            v_norm = vel[i] / np.linalg.norm(vel[i])
            n_norms = vel[neighbors] / (np.linalg.norm(vel[neighbors], axis=1, keepdims
                =True) + 1e-5)
            local_order[i] = max(0.0, np.mean(np.dot(n_norms, v_norm)))

    # Force clamping helper
    def limit(vectors, max_val):
        norms = np.linalg.norm(vectors, axis=1, keepdims=True)
        norms[norms == 0] = 1.0
        return np.where(norms > max_val, (vectors / norms) * max_val, vectors)

    sep = limit(sep_steer, MAX_FORCE) * W_SEP
    ali = limit(ali_steer, MAX_FORCE) * W_ALI
    coh = limit(coh_steer, MAX_FORCE) * W_COH

    # Soft Boundary Force
    boundary_force = np.zeros_like(vel)
    margin = 12.0
```

```
    turn_factor = 0.28

    boundary_force[pos[:, 0] < margin, 0] += turn_factor
    boundary_force[pos[:, 0] > WIDTH - margin, 0] -= turn_factor
    boundary_force[pos[:, 1] < margin, 1] += turn_factor
    boundary_force[pos[:, 1] > HEIGHT - margin, 1] -= turn_factor

    acceleration = sep + ali + coh + boundary_force
    new_vel = limit(vel + acceleration, MAX_SPEED)
    new_pos = pos + new_vel

    # Hard clamp fallback
    new_pos[:, 0] = np.clip(new_pos[:, 0], 1, WIDTH - 1)
    new_pos[:, 1] = np.clip(new_pos[:, 1], 1, HEIGHT - 1)

    return new_pos, new_vel, local_order

# Precompute trajectory
print(f"Calculating flocking physics ({DURATION_SEC}s, {TOTAL_FRAMES} frames)...")
pos_seq = np.zeros((TOTAL_FRAMES, NUM_BOIDS, 2))
vel_seq = np.zeros((TOTAL_FRAMES, NUM_BOIDS, 2))
order_seq = np.zeros((TOTAL_FRAMES, NUM_BOIDS))
global_order_metric = np.zeros(TOTAL_FRAMES)

curr_pos = positions.copy()
curr_vel = velocities.copy()

for f in range(TOTAL_FRAMES):
    pos_seq[f] = curr_pos
    vel_seq[f] = curr_vel
    curr_pos, curr_vel, local_ord = update_physics(curr_pos, curr_vel)
    order_seq[f] = local_ord

    # Global Polarization Order Parameter (0% to 100%)
    mean_velocity = np.mean(curr_vel, axis=0)
    avg_speed = np.mean(np.linalg.norm(curr_vel, axis=1))
    global_order_metric[f] = (np.linalg.norm(mean_velocity) / (avg_speed + 1e-5)) *
        100.0

# ==========================================
# 3. HIGH-CONTRAST MOBILE RENDERER (9:16)
# ==========================================
fig, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(6, 10.66), facecolor="#020202")
ax.set_facecolor("#020202")
ax.set_xlim(0, WIDTH)
ax.set_ylim(0, HEIGHT)
ax.axis("off")

cmap = plt.cm.plasma

# Directional Arrow Boids
quiver = ax.quiver(
    pos_seq[0, :, 0], pos_seq[0, :, 1],
    vel_seq[0, :, 0], vel_seq[0, :, 1],
    order_seq[0],
    cmap=cmap, clim=[0.0, 1.0],
    scale=34, width=0.008,
```

```
    headwidth=4.5, headlength=5.0, headaxislength=4.5,
    pivot='mid', alpha=0.95
)

# Glow Halo Points
glow = ax.scatter(
    pos_seq[0, :, 0], pos_seq[0, :, 1],
    c=order_seq[0], cmap=cmap, vmin=0.0, vmax=1.0,
    s=55, alpha=0.35, edgecolors='none'
)

# Scientific HUD Overlay
hud_title = ax.text(0.05, 0.95, "EPISODE 02 // BOIDS EMERGENCE", transform=ax.
    transAxes,
                    color="#FFFFFF", fontsize=11, fontfamily="monospace", weight="bold")
hud_timer = ax.text(0.05, 0.92, "", transform=ax.transAxes,
                    color="#A0A0A0", fontsize=9, fontfamily="monospace")
hud_order = ax.text(0.05, 0.89, "", transform=ax.transAxes,
                    color="#00E5FF", fontsize=10, fontfamily="monospace", weight="bold")
hud_state = ax.text(0.05, 0.86, "", transform=ax.transAxes,
                    color="#FFD700", fontsize=9, fontfamily="monospace")

ax.text(0.05, 0.03, "RULES: 1.Separate 2.Align 3.Cohere", transform=ax.transAxes,
        color="#666666", fontsize=8, fontfamily="monospace")

def update(frame):
    pos = pos_seq[frame]
    vel = vel_seq[frame]
    ord_val = order_seq[frame]
    current_time = frame / FPS
    order_pct = global_order_metric[frame]

    quiver.set_offsets(pos)
    quiver.set_UVC(vel[:, 0], vel[:, 1])
    quiver.set_array(ord_val)

    glow.set_offsets(pos)
    glow.set_array(ord_val)

    hud_timer.set_text(f"TIME: {current_time:04.1f}s / {DURATION_SEC}.0s")
    bar_length = int(order_pct / 10)
    bar_display = "[" + "#" * bar_length + "-" * (10 - bar_length) + "]"
    hud_order.set_text(f"SWARM ORDER: {order_pct:04.1f}% {bar_display}")

    if current_time < 3.5:
        hud_state.set_text("PHASE: 1. RANDOM DISPERSION (CHAOS)")
        hud_state.set_color("#FF5555")
    elif current_time < 9.0:
        hud_state.set_text("PHASE: 2. LOCAL SYNC (CLUSTER FORMATION)")
        hud_state.set_color("#FFAA00")
    else:
        hud_state.set_text("PHASE: 3. GLOBAL SWARM INTELLIGENCE")
        hud_state.set_color("#00FFCC")

    return quiver, glow, hud_timer, hud_order, hud_state

ani = FuncAnimation(fig, update, frames=TOTAL_FRAMES, interval=1000/FPS, blit=True)
```

```
output_name = "boids_flocking_20s.gif"
print(f"Rendering 500 frames to {output_name}...")
ani.save(output_name, writer=PillowWriter(fps=FPS))
print(f"Export successful: {output_name}")
```

5 Step-by-Step Mobile Execution & File Export

1. **Initialize Script File:** Open a text file within the Ubuntu shell:

```
nano boids.py
```

2. **Save Buffer:** Paste the source code above. Write out and exit using `Ctrl + O`, `Enter`, then `Ctrl + X`.

3. **Execute Numerical Integration & Rendering:**

```
python3 boids.py
```

NumPy precomputes the 500 frames of kinematics in seconds, after which Pillow renders the animation frames until displaying `Export successful`.

4. **Export to Device Gallery:** Move the generated animation to primary mobile storage:

```
exit
cp ~/ubuntu/root/boids_flocking_20s.gif /sdcard/Download/
```

Open the `Download` directory inside your device file manager to inspect the result.

6 Physical & Dynamical Phase Analysis

Upon playing the animation, observe the three distinct dynamical phases:

```
[0.0s - 3.5s]   ⟶  [3.5s - 9.0s]   ⟶  [9.0s - 20.0s]
Random Dispersion (Chaos)   ⟶  Local Sync (Clusters)   ⟶  Global Swarm Emergence
 Order:  10% - 25% (Warm Hues)     Order:  40% - 75% (Color Shift)     Order:  90%+
                                  (Neon Cyan Lock)
```

1. **Phase 1: Isotropic Chaos** ($0.0\text{s} - 3.5\text{s}$)**:** Initial headings are uniformly random. Local collisions trigger intense separation responses, keeping average alignment low ($\Phi < 25\%$). Warm purple and orange hues predominate.

2. **Phase 2: Local Cluster Nucleation** ($3.5\text{s} - 9.0\text{s}$)**:** Alignment and cohesion overcome dispersive perturbations. Micro-flocks of 5 to 15 agents consolidate and turn collectively, causing polarization metrics to rise sharply.

3. **Phase 3: Global Coherent Flocking (9.0s − 20.0s):** Micro-clusters coalesce into an undulating, unified stream. The polarization parameter stabilizes above 90%, with all agents locking into an aligned cyan hue that navigates the vertical boundaries organically.

7 Computational Experiments & Research Challenges

Modify parameters in `boids.py` to examine non-equilibrium phase boundaries:

> **Challenge 1: Flocking Breakdown Test**
> Nullify the alignment weight (`W_ALI = 0.0`). Observe whether cohesion and separation alone can sustain a coherent flock, or if agents disintegrate into an aimless swarm.

> **Challenge 2: Over-Separation Dispersion**
> Double the collision avoidance radius (`MIN_DISTANCE = 8.4`). Quantify how this inflated personal zone inhibits the emergence of localized clusters.

> **Challenge 3: Critical Density Threshold**
> Reduce the population from 130 to 30 boids (`NUM_BOIDS = 30`). Determine whether a sub-critical density prevents agents from discovering one another and achieving global synchronization.